

cut short the development time.

In recent years, the US has shown its advanced capability in Iraq war and then in Afghanistan. Has India reached that level?

Technology-wise, we have come quite close and are not far behind European and American countries. However, we still import most of the advanced equipment. To develop the technology within India, the government of India has come out with Defence Procurement Procedures. This is applicable for all defence contracts which exceed Rs 30 million of value. The government has put a condition that 30 per cent of it has to be procured from within India through manufacture under transfer of technology agreement, etc. That's called defence offset. It has given an impetus to the Indian industry to grow and advance the technology because it's getting the foreign technology directly.

What all new devices are under development for the Indian military?

There is one programme called futuristic infantry soldier as a system where the soldier's suit will incorporate everything necessary for the soldier to communicate with his colleagues and be in touch with his commanders and also detect enemy movements and take action. This will include GPS, communication network, infrared (IR) camera, wearable computer and so on. The armaments are also becoming more and more advanced, fitted with high-precision pointing systems and sensors including laser-range finders and IR sensors. Night-vision equipment are also there. Helmets are being fitted with IR camera so that the soldiers can see in the dark.

Are these being used currently?

We have partly started using them and the use is growing. Another development is unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs). We are also getting into unmanned under-water vehicles and unmanned land vehicles. These equipment can be used without risking the lives of soldiers.

Are these UAVs ready for use?

Development takes place in phases. Like we have already successfully developed pilotless target aircraft Lakshya and a variety of UAVs like Nishant and Rustom. Lakshya is already in use. Development of the next level of UAVs is also complete and these are going into production. High-altitude and high-capability UAVs are under development.

Going forward, how do you see the demand for defence electronics equipment in India?

The demand is very good as the threat perception is changing. If your enemy is becoming more and more capable and using more advance technology, you have to keep

pace with him. Our own equipment have become quite old in technology and we need more advanced and sophisticated equipment. That way, the demand is growing.

Talking of the market in India, what all players are active in this field?

We are into missile launches, gun upgrades, electronic warfare and air defence (both hardware and software). In the private sector, it's only Larsen & Toubro other than us which is a major player in defence electronics. In the public sector, there are Bharat Electronics Ltd (BEL) and to some extent ECIL. But main competition is from BEL.

We are taking a balanced approach of developing systems in-house as well sourcing technology from abroad in order to cut short the development time

Anything more about Tata Power SED.

This is a division of Tata Power Company Ltd which is into strategic electronics. We have been working for defence for almost 40 years. All of our products so far have been for military. But now we have set up a world-class manufacturing facility in Bengaluru that will be used not only to meet our own internal requirements but also for all other industries (automotive, communication, etc) through electronic manufacturing services. Our internal capacity utilisation is 15-20 per cent, so we want to offer it to other industries. In fact, we want to grow it as another strategic business unit.

Not many know that Tata Power is also into strategic electronics. Why has it kept a low profile?

It's for historical reasons. It's in the last three to four years only that the government has relaxed the policy for the private sector too to get into defence. Till now we had been only developing and supplying to DRDO and BEL. As it was not direct supply to defence, there was no publicity that we are a defence company. Also, we were making small volumes. Now that the policy has been relaxed and the private sector invited to participate in defence programmes, we have started getting direct contracts from defence.

Tata Power is a power generating and distribution company that has been there for a hundred years now. This division was started in 1967 as an in-house R&D centre for developing electronic equipment for internal use. Then there was requirement from defence (like DRDO lab) for high-quality, high-reliability products, which we started taking up for development. Once the development was successful, they wanted us to manufacture also. So we set up a manufacturing division in Bengaluru in 1981. It has grown from there; we started with a turnover of Rs 3-4 million but now our order book is in the region of Rs 20 billion. ●